

PRELUDE

Why this book needed to be written now?

Over the past century, three major intellectual traditions have been circling the same question from different angles:

What happens to the human mind when its informational environment changes faster than it can adapt?

In the mid-20th century, systems theorists began describing the world as a mesh of interacting feedback loops. They noticed that human behavior, cultural norms, and even emotional states were downstream of systemic pressures, not isolated personal choices. Complexity did not simply increase — it reorganized the very conditions under which minds make sense of experience.

Around the same time, media ecologists observed that new communication technologies reshape cognition long before society recognizes what has happened. Print reorganized thought into linear sequences. Television reorganized attention into rapid, high-stimulus bursts. Every medium altered not just what we consumed but *who we became*.

In the 21st century, a third lineage emerged: AI cognition and compression theory.

These fields recognized that digital systems do not interpret the world — they compress it. They reduce patterns into representations optimized for storage, speed, and retrieval. As AI models advanced, they began to reflect compressed versions of culture back to us, influencing human expression in return. A recursive loop formed: **human** → **machine** → **human**.

Each of these disciplines identified a part of the same larger phenomenon, but none named the whole.

This book does.

Reality Drift is the unifying framework that integrates these traditions. It describes how modern environments — defined by accelerating entropy, recursive compression, and mediated attention — create conditions in which

The Age of Drift

coherence becomes difficult to maintain. Not because individuals are failing, but because the structure of reality itself is reorganizing around them.

The premise is straightforward:

When the rate of informational change exceeds the mind's capacity for integration, experience becomes unstable.

This instability touches language, identity, meaning, and perception.

It produces a distinctive pattern of cultural and cognitive outcomes that earlier scholars observed in fragments but lacked the conceptual tools to fully articulate.

The purpose of this book is not to critique technology, romanticize the past, or prescribe a return to earlier ways of living.

Its purpose is to provide a clear conceptual model for understanding the forces reshaping the modern mind.

What earlier eras experienced over centuries, ours experiences in months.

What once happened slowly and invisibly now happens globally and in real time.

This book needed to be written now because we have reached the point where the effects are no longer theoretical.

They are structural.

Measurable.

Culturally synchronized.

And distributed across billions of people simultaneously.

Reality Drift is not an anomaly, a pathology, or a temporary disruption.

It is the cognitive condition of the 21st century.

Understanding it is the first step toward navigating it